

Ball Lightning Observations on Sliding Doors - John Cross (1964 and 1984)

Abstract

Ball lightning was observed twice in two different locations, but under similar circumstances. In each case, lightning struck to a tree at some distance from the house. After a short delay, a luminous ball appeared on the inside of a sliding glass door. It then began to float through the room, where it disappeared into an electric outlet in the first instance and flew into the screen of a TV set during the second occurrence. The two blue balls looked very similar, appeared to be spinning and threw off white sparks.

John Cross

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I live near New Castle, PA. We are 60 miles north of Pittsburgh.

Age: 74 (in 2024)

2907 Old Plank Rd, New Castle, PA 16105

First home (1964): PO box 81, Stoneboro, PA [Age: 14]
House right at the top of Elm Street
Mercer county, PA

Now:

44 Elm St Ext
Stoneboro, PA 16153
USA

Elevation: 374 m (21 m above lake level)

➤ House at 44 Elm Street Ext.: 41.3411, -80.1010

Lightning struck wild cherry tree, no longer there

Second home (1984): Rural Route 2, PO box 162 [Age: 34]
Rockwood, Somerset county, PA
Next to Laurel Hill Creek, Village of Trent
Near Trenthouse Inn, 2008 Copper Kettle HWY

Now:

Barron Church Rd
Trent, Rockwood, PA
USA

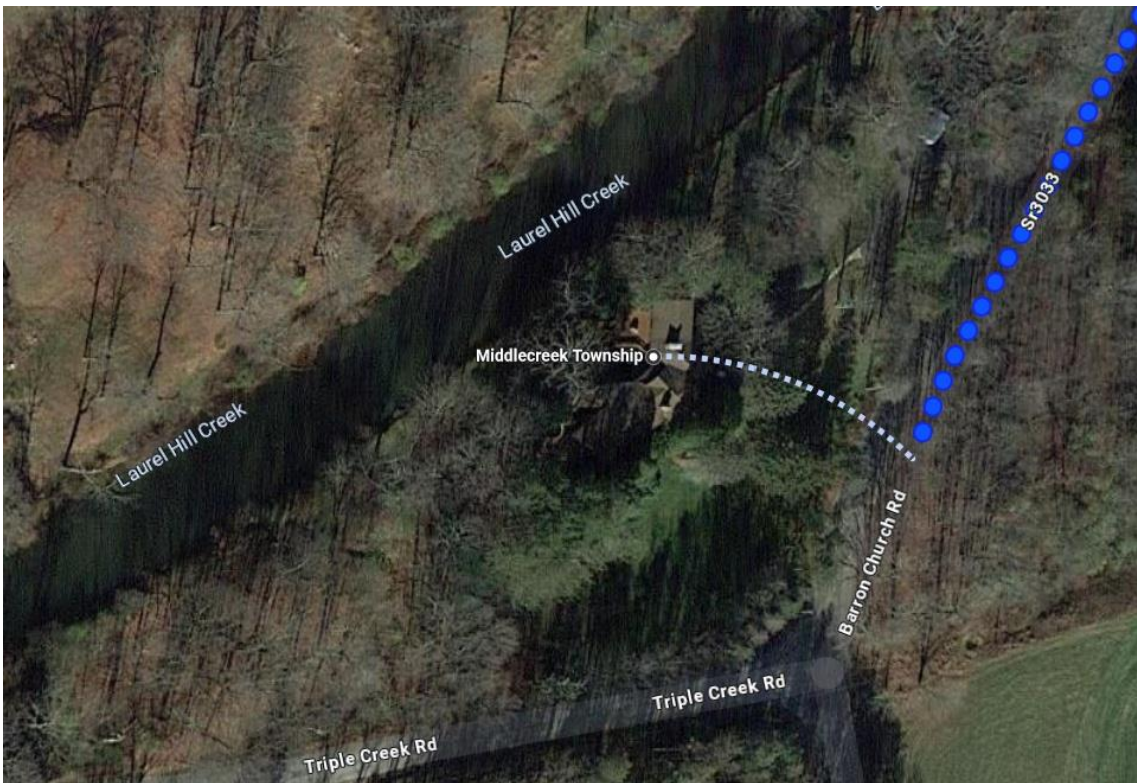
Elevation: 587 m (4 m above river level)

➤ House at Laurel Hill Creek: 39.9829, -79.2480

Lightning struck oak tree, tree is still there



House in Stoneboro, PA



House in Trent, Rockwood, PA

Report from Jan. 21, 2024

I have seen ball lightning in the house twice in my life. Both times similar with the ball seeming to come through a sliding glass door. The first time lightning struck a tree about 20 yards from the sliding door. A blue rotating ball came through the door. It appeared to have sparks spinning off. It floated around the room hovering and darting. It crossed the room and disappeared into an electrical outlet.

The second time, in a different home, lightning struck a tree about 20 yards from a sliding glass door in my bedroom. It came through the glass again hovering and floating. This time it went into the TV screen. The TV did not work after that. It seemed to hover directly over my head both times. I was awestruck both times and did not move.

Additional Info

The two incidents were similar. The first observation was around 1964 [corrected]. I was 14. I was watching TV in a family room of a new home my parents had built. This was in Stoneboro, PA in Mercer County.

The room was rectangular and stretched across the width of the house. At one end of the wall was a stone fireplace with a sliding glass door beside it. The glass in the sliding door was about 8' x 8'. The lightning struck a wild cherry tree fairly close to the glass door. I would guess 25'. The lightning struck drawing my eye to the glass door. A short time later the ball seemed to pop through the glass. It just sat there for a moment. I had the feeling it was scoping out the room. Then it began to move, slowly from side to side and down the room. I think it was being attracted to a grounding source. It began to dart a bit more quickly. I came over my head once or twice. This did not happen, instantaneously. It is difficult to judge time when something like this happens. It took what seemed like almost 10 seconds. It finally made its way to the other end of the room, beside a doorway to the garage, which ran parallel to the room. It entered a receptacle. I don't remember if it was an electrical outlet or a telephone jack. The ball came close to the receptacle and looked like it just got sucked in. There were no sparks or noise. It just quietly went in. The ball was a dark blue like a gas range flame. There seemed to be some white interspersed with the blue. Looking at one face of the ball it appeared more like a circular saw with teeth. The teeth were throwing off sparks.

The second incident occurred in the mid 1980's. I had worked for Federated Investors in Pittsburgh and did very well. I had a beautiful home along the Laurel Hill Creek near Seven Springs ski resort. Again, I was watching television in my bedroom. It was quite a large room with an alcove at one corner, leading to a deck with a hot tub. Beside the deck was a large oak tree. Lightning struck the tree, and shortly thereafter the same sort of blue ball popped through the sliding glass door. It came out of the alcove. It moved slowly around the room hovering over my head a couple of times again. Again it moved as though being attracted to a ground source. It moved back across the room and into an older type television sitting on a stand halfway between the floor and ceiling. It went through the glass on the screen without breaking anything. It must've burnt out the circuitry because the TV would not work. The ball was exactly the same as the first one. Both trees had lightning damage like splits in the trunk and possibly some branches broken.

2024-02-01 JC: Location of the houses

The first house is still in the Borough of Stoneboro PA. Our address was PO box 81 Stoneboro PA. The house was to the right at the top of Elm Street. They had no house numbers then in Stoneboro. We got our mail at the Post Office. This is in Mercer County PA. Probably not enough info.

The second home was Rural Route 2 more commonly known RD 2 Box 162 Rockwood, PA. This was Somerset County PA. Our mail was delivered to a mail box next to the road by a rural carrier. We bordered the Laurel Hill State Park. We lived next to the Laurel Hill Creek. It was the Village of Trent. We were about 3 miles from the Seven Springs Ski Resort. The house is still there. Again probably not enough info.

These incidents happened in about 1964 and 1984. I will try to get you some pictures.

The two spheres were almost identical. My recollection would be about 14" diameter. They were a blue similar to the color of a natural gas flame. There was white interspersed in the blue. The balls rotated slowly seeming to throw off sparks from the edge.

It was 1964. I can see my property in Trent. Look down the road from the Trent House. Go along the creek a short way. You will see Trent picnic area across the creek from me. You will see a triangular property right against the creek. That is where my house is.

On the Stoneboro map you are showing Elm St Extension. I was right near the end of Elm St right at the intersection of Elm and Elm St. Extension. It is to the right. A split level with a large garage next to Elm. I am going to look for the picture of the house in Trent now.

The bottom back corner of the house is where the tree was that was struck. That would be the Elm street house. There is a tree pictured that could have been the same tree. The sliding glass door is on that same back corner.

On the Trent house, the lightning struck a tree between the house and creek. It was on the left back corner as you face the creek. The sliding doors were right in the same area. It looks like the oak tree is still there in Trent.

2024-02-03 WH: Sliding patio doors

You mentioned that the sliding door in Stoneboro was about 8 feet x 8 feet in size (2.40 m squared). I'm trying to get an idea how these doors are built. Was this a single large pane, or was it subdivided into several smaller ones? Or two, if the door was split in the middle. If so, in which of them did the BL appear? Did this door have double pane windows? Of what material was the frame made, wood, PVC, aluminum?

In your house in Trent, was the patio door already there or did you have that put in? I found that Andersen and Lowe's offer such doors and windows. Probably others as well.

Concerning the fireplace in Stoneboro: did you burn wood there or was it for gas, oil? Must have had its own chimney too. Was there a fireplace in the room where you saw the BL in Trent as well?

Reply

We had just built the house in Stoneboro. Sliding glass doors are usually used to walk through to a patio area. Most are in 2 panels of the same size. One is fixed, the other slides back to cover the other panel. There is a sliding screen on the outside of the panel that slides. These are all in tracks. These doors are always Thermopane, two panels of glass. I believe the door frames and tracks in Stoneboro were aluminum. The fireplace was wood burning. I might also add the garage was in the far end of the house. The family room where this took place was beside and parallel to the garage. So the sliding door was 10 or 15 feet from the back corner of the garage. I can't be sure but the ball appeared near the center of the entire door. Both height and width.

The house in Trent was originally a rustic log cabin. I hired an architect and we added 3 wings with a series of decks down toward the creek. There was a deck with a hot tub off of the bedroom where this took place. There were two sets of sliding doors on the back corner. One set was around the corner from the other. The ball came through the door facing the creek. I think these doors may have had 3 panels. These were wood frames with metal tracks. The ball came in near the center as I recall.

2024-02-03 WH: Lightning strike

It seems that we already have some useful information: the two lightning strikes which created the BLs were both negative cloud to ground (CG) strikes. If they had been positive strikes, they would have been much more energetic, probably destroyed the trees and damaged the houses (cracked the windows). The current of the lightning bolts will have been in an intermediate range. I would guess 20-35 kA. I once visited the location where a tree had been hit by a 60 kA positive lightning bolt that lasted 200 ms, as measured by a lightning detection system from Siemens. The tree was still there, with some damage to its trunk. Also, a house 20 m away from the tree had broken tiles and windows, though it was not directly struck.

I realize that this was a long time ago, but did you see if the lightning flickered, or was it just one single strike? How bright was it? About half of the CG lightning strikes have several after strikes with 10-100 milliseconds in between, which makes the lightning channel appear to flicker.

Reply

The cabin had lightning rods. There was a wood burning stove in the bedroom. The shingles on the roof were cedar shake. I would say I saw flickering I think I saw fragments of lightning kind of bouncing off the trees. I would say the screens at the cabin were most likely plastic I don't know about the screens in Stoneboro. The screen frames at the cabin were metal. I think I recall the lightning ball coming through the fixed panels with no screen but right near the center of the doors.

You and Dr. Lowke seem to not know what we call sliding glass doors. I would say 90% of the homes in the US built after 1960 have some sort of sliding glass doors. We are more extravagant here with heat. You are more sensible. As an aside my Grandmother emigrated from Leipzig before the WWI. Her name was Richter. She traveled on the Rotterdam. My Grandfather was on the crew of the Rotterdam. He was from Scheveningen in the Netherlands. They met on the ship and married soon after. They bought a farm in Stoneboro. He lost the farm during the depression. Being a tight Dutchman he was able to have squirreled away enough money to buy a portable feed mill. He ground cow feed at the farms. Farmers had to have feed ground even during the depression. He did well.

2024-02-04 WH: Size of trees and houses

The cabin in Trent had lightning rods, but the lightning chose to hit the tree instead.

- What size was that tree and how big was the house, in Trent and in Stoneboro?
- Did you happen to see the lightning on the trees in both cases?
- Was it dark outside or did this happen during the daytime?
- How loud was the thunder?

About the sliding doors: no, we're not that luxurious here. Would be nice to have one though.

- Did the door that you had installed have Low-E glass? That would be a conductive coating on one of the inner surfaces, which reflects IR light. This would be interesting to know because it reflects radio waves also.
- Was there a protection on the glass in the form of a clear plastic layer, which keeps the pieces together in case it cracks?

Very charming story of your grandparents. Your grandmother left Germany by ship and even found her husband during the trip. Two brothers of my grandfather emigrated to Brazil in the 1920ies. My family lived in Washington, D.C. from 1970-80, where I went to high school. We also took a ship on several travels, once from Hamburg to New York.

Reply

That was a tall oak at the cabin. You would not be able to get your arms around it. I guess 3' diameter. I can see it in the Google earth picture. In both cases I was facing the door. I heard a very loud crash of thunder both times. I could see lightning striking the tree. I would say 15 to 20' off the ground. I could not see too far up because of the wall above the glass. I was back 15' or so from the door. As far as coatings on the glass I am not sure. I think there is a space between the inside glass and outside glass. They are not like clear window glass. There is more to them. I never did now the square footage of the homes.

The house in Stoneboro was a Split Level. It was built on sloping ground. Garage and family room and powder room on the first level. That is where this took place. Down 5 steps to a finished basement. Up 5 steps to the main entrance foyer, the kitchen and living room. Up 6 steps or so to three good sized bedrooms and bathroom. Probably a fairly average square footage for a split level at the time.

The cabin was larger and sprawling. The original log building contained kitchen, large great room. Loft over the kitchen, entrance foyer and hallway around the back of the cabin were added. Two wings at an angle going toward the creek. Between the wings were decks on several levels going down toward the creek. One of the decks had a large oak in it. The bedroom bathroom and walk in closet were added too, in another wing on the side of the cabin. Basement with bedrooms under everything but the bedroom wing. It had a crawl space. Both homes had hot water heat with copper pipes. 3 bathrooms. 4 fireplaces [Stoneboro had 1 fireplace].

2024-02-08 WH: Ball lightning properties

You mentioned that the ball lightning appeared at about in the center of the sliding door, a few seconds after a lightning strike.

- Do you remember in what month or season this happened?
- What was the time of the day, was it dark outside?
- Did you have lights on inside, or only the TV running?
- How long did it take from the lightning strike to the appearance of the BL?
Can you make an estimate in seconds?
- Did the BL fly in from outside or could it have come into existence next to the door glass itself? Have you noticed the BL outside beyond the glass door, or only when it was inside the room?
- Were you already looking at the window when the BL appeared, because of the lightning strike? Did the BL somehow develop or was it just there, full size, from one instant to the next?
- Did you see both BLs already on the glass of the sliding door, or did you see the one in Trent only a bit later when it came out of the alcove?
- At what height did they move through the room?
- How fast did they move?
- Did the BL grow after appearing inside on the glass (while it sat there) or was it already full size?
- How long did the BL in Rockwood sit on the glass before it started moving through the room? Did the size or brightness of the BL change over time?
- For how many seconds were the BLs visible?
- How far did they travel during that time?
- How bright were the BLs? If you compare them to an incandescent lamp, how many watts would that have?
- Did you notice any sound or smell? Heat or static electricity?
- What was the closest distance between you and the BLs?
- About the appearance: did both BLs look like a sawblade shooting sparks, or just the first one?
- What color did these sparks have and how far did they fly?
- Were the BLs transparent or opaque? Did they have a halo?
- You mentioned some white structures in the blue sphere. How did they look and did these structures move?
- Did the BL rotate? If so, in which direction?
- How did you feel in the presence of the BLs?

Would it be possible for you to make a sketch of the appearance of the BLs? Doesn't need to have a high artistic quality, but it would help us to envision how the BLs looked.

Reply

I can't remember the month or season. It was evening before bed both times when I would watch TV. I had lights on in both cases. Both rooms had recessed lighting in the ceilings on rheostats. Both rooms had older type telephones.

It took a second or so after the strikes for the balls to appear. The balls most likely formed on or near the inside glass. I was looking at the glass both times because of the strike. Both balls were just there. I did not see them outside. They appeared and were stationary at first. They did not grow. Then they started moving a bit higher than my head while seated. They would move, stop, change direction and seemed to change speed. They generally moved slowly then would stop then take off in a different direction and sometimes move more quickly. I felt they were being attracted to different areas or objects and moved more quickly to stronger attractions.

In both cases they passed directly over my head several times and even stopped there. I could see directly in the alcove. The alcove was good sized maybe 15' x 15'. I saw the ball appear inside the glass just like the first one. Neither ball grew. I genuinely had the feeling the balls appeared and stood still to scope out the room.

The way they moved gave me the feeling I was being stalked. I could not move other than to pull my neck down into my shoulders. I did not want to move and especially stand up because my head would be at the ball level. The balls did not change height much. The TV was on a high stand near the height of the ball. The ball in Stoneboro had to go lower to enter the receptacle. Both balls moved quickly as they entered the TV and receptacle.

One last thought. I have always had a thing with static electricity. When I was young I couldn't wear my Mickey Mouse watch. It would not run on me. The adults said I had too much electricity. All of my life I really have been jolted by static electricity. It is sometimes painful. It often makes my arm tighten up. I am careful about it. I have wondered if the balls hovered over me because of my charged being. Thank you for the YouTube link [Fairbury power plant]. Most interesting.

Both BLs were the same. They looked like saw blades with sparks for teeth. Both balls rotated with the sparks curving in a circular way. Like water might spin from a car tire. No change in brightness. The balls were opaque. The balls were bright. I have no idea what brightness in watts. It is hard to say the time they were visible. I guess it would be over 10 seconds.

I saw both balls on or in front of the glass as they appeared. Both balls sat there a second or two before moving. No static electricity. No smell. They both moved 25' to 30' if it were a straight line. However, there was movement from side to side. The ball in Trent came 20' out of the alcove over my bed where I was sitting. There was a wall behind the bed. The ball approached the wall and went 10' back again over the bed to the TV sitting to the left of the alcove. The family room in Stoneboro was a long rectangular room. The ball went from the sliding door to the receptacle maybe 25'. It moved from side to side. Both balls came directly over my head as I was sitting on a bed and on a couch. Probably 3'.

The first time I was thinking what the hell is this. I never knew lightning formed balls. I then started to think my God. Is that thing going to hit me and what will it do? Then I felt relief when it went away. This was along with the feeling of being stalked. I told some people about it. They just said "Oh". No internet then so it was some years before I knew what it was. The second time I thought not this again. And again I hope that thing does not hit me. I knew what it was this time. Neither time did it upset me much. I was awestruck. I felt like boy that was a close one. I felt no sickness or tingling or anything in the presence of ball lightning.

I will attempt to make a sketch later.



This is what the BLs remind me of when sitting in front of the glass. Tasmanian Devil cartoon.
Sent from my iPhone

WH: Great :) Is that you or the ball lightning?
You certainly wouldn't know what it had in mind.

2024-02-09 WH: Newly installed Thermopane doors

It appears that at least in Trent, the sliding door and the house in general were still quite new when the ball lightning appeared. Maybe 5 years old or less?

Trent:

- When did you buy this house and after rebuilding it, in which year did you move in? (Windows put in fairly recently before 1984)
- Do you still own this house or does it belong to someone that you know?
- What kind of wood did you burn in the fireplace?
- Did the lightning strike also cause damage, like blown fuses and the like or did it damage the electric installations of the hot tub?

Stoneboro:

- How many years before 1964 had the windows and the sliding door been installed? Maybe that was before your time, but perhaps you remember it if you moved into a new house a few years earlier.
- What height did the wild cherry tree have approximately? Was it higher than the house?

Reply

I bought the log house in Trent in about 1980. I moved in in 1980. Could have been 79. The original log house was built in the 1930s. When I bought it the previous owners had built the bedroom addition. About 1984 we added the extensive additions. I believe the bedroom was expanded by 12 feet or so to make the alcove with sliding doors. Beside the alcove in the addition was a walk in closet. The deck and hot tub were added at this time in 1984. We must have installed the sliding doors at this time too. There was no damage to the hot tub or the circuitry in the house. The ball exited through the screen on the TV. The TV turned off and would not work after that. I no longer own the home and don't know who lives there. We burned hardwoods. Ash, cherry, and oak mainly. We did not burn softwood like pine.

We built the house new in Stoneboro in about 1962. We lived in one part of the house in Stoneboro while the rest was being built. The house was finished somewhere around 1964. Those sliding doors were installed between 62 and 64. The cherry tree was about 2' in diameter

and it was taller than the house. This is a wild cherry and nothing like a smaller edible fruit bearing cherry tree.

I sent for some supplies today to attempt to draw the ball. I plan to send some diagrams of the bedroom and the family room. I have very good pictures of the cabin inside and out. I am still trying to locate them. They were taken by a professional photographer to make a brochure for the realtor who sold the house.

And yes both sets of sliding doors were new in 1964 and 1984.

2024-02-10 WH: Photos, weather, spin of the BL

Very interesting. BL have been seen coming through normal windows for a long time, but the Thermopane double glass windows appear to be especially suited for them. Which is very odd. Do you still have photos of your parent's house, or would that mean driving there to take them?

Some more questions that have come to my mind or that I had forgotten to ask:

- Weather. Evidently, there was lightning. Was there also a thunderstorm raging or was it still comparatively calm? Was it raining at the time when the lightning hit the trees?
- Spin of the BL. How fast was the BL spinning and in which direction? Did the BL spin around a vertical or horizontal axis (or at which angle)? My guess would be, that the BL would keep the spin direction with which it was created throughout its existence, like a spinning top. Was this so, or did the direction, in which the spin axis was pointing, change?
- Was the fireplace burning?
- Did any of your neighbors report similar observations?

Reply

It was dark out. It was a thunderstorm with rain. In both cases.

As far as the spinning goes, as I looked at both balls I was seeing more of a flat surface like a circular saw. I believe I did not see the orb because the sparks or tendrils appeared to be coming from the edges of the saw blade. I think the white interspersed with the blue surface facing me could have been sparks encircling the entire orb. I don't remember the rotation changing direction. I really can't say if it was spinning clockwise or counterclockwise. I could see it rotating slowly. As it rotated the sparks would curve back slightly in the opposite direction of the rotation. It would be like if you rotated a wet bicycle tire, the water would come off the tire in a direction opposite of the rotation. It would not fly straight out.

The sparks were white and possibly a very light shade of blue. The center was dark blue with white interspersed. When I spoke of seeing a flat surface, it would be like looking at the moon. It is hard to see it as an orb. Then with sparks around the edges, it would be even harder to see as an orb.

Would not Thermopane be a better insulator than a single pane?

2024-02-10 JC: Stoneboro Photos

I drove. It is about 30 miles [from New Castle]. I met the woman. She took the inside pictures and sent them to me while I was there. She did not invite me in. She was not a native of Stoneboro. I did not meet the husband. She became much more friendly after we talked for a while. They are teachers and coaches at the local high school. The husband is a science teacher. She had not heard of BL but says her husband would know about it.

The sliding door has been replaced with a bay window. I was lying on the couch on the left side of the room. My feet were toward the fireplace. I could look straight out through the sliding glass door. The TV was on the right wall in about the middle of the wall. Further down the right wall beside and to the left of the door to the garage were light switches and rheostat. Below were an electric receptacle and phone jack. The TV jack may have been there too. The ball went into the electrical receptacle.

The cherry tree is gone. If you look at the picture down the side of the house, you will see leaves on the top of the bank. On the edge of that picture you will see a tree trunk. The cherry tree was just on the top of the bank directly up from the trunk.



Stoneboro, 44 Elm St Ext



Family room



Fireplace

2024-02-11 WH: Stoneboro

The garage was next to one side of the family room and probably the kitchen on the other side. There were four fireplaces, but I can see only one chimney. The other three probably had different flues that were built into the same chimney.

- Did this house have a metal roofing at the time when you lived there?
- Are all the fireplaces on the same side of the house?
- Were these fireplaces used for heating the house in 1964, or was there an additional heating system also? On one photo, I see a propane tank standing next to the house. That could be new, of course.
- Did the fireplace have a glass door in front of it, in 1964?
- Do you perhaps recall if there was a fire burning when you saw the BL?
- What is the rheostat that you mentioned - a dimmer for the lighting?
- Now it would be possible to actually measure the distance from where the trunk of the cherry tree was to the sliding door i.e. bay window. I have the impression that this could be a bit more than 20-25 ft. More like 35 ft but that is only a guess.

The house where I lived in Washington D.C. in the 1970ies had a central hot air heating with a gas stove. We had no A/C. We also had two ceremonial fireplaces in which we burned wood. Our fireplaces did not have a glass door in front of it. There was a large chimney on the side of the house, similar to yours.

Reply

The house in Stoneboro has only one fireplace. The house in Trent has four. The roof was not metal at the time. Regular asphalt shingles.

There were no fires burning in either house.

Both houses had hot water baseboard heat with copper pipes. I believe it was oil at the time. You are most likely correct about the distance the tree was from the house. 35.

We had a metal screen in front of the fireplace like chainmail that you pulled cords to open and close.

The rheostat is the same as a dimmer.

There was no AC in either house.

The house in Stoneboro is a split level. From the family room there are 2 stair wells side by side at the back corner. One five steps down to a finished basement. The other 5 steps up to a foyer, kitchen and living room. From this level steps up again to 3 bedrooms and a bathroom. There was a powder room at the end of the family room, opposite from the fireplace. Shower, toilet and sink. Copper pipes.

2024-02-11 WH: Stoneboro

Now I just learned what a copper baseboard heater is. I've seen them before, but didn't know what was inside. In addition to the heater itself - plenty of dust, usually. This makes a grid of copper tubing around the floor of all rooms.

- Do you remember where this heater was installed in the fireplace room?
I can't spot it on the photos, because the room is very stuffed now.
- The door which opens from the garage - does that lead directly into the family room or to a small corridor in front of it?

Reply

The furnace unit was located in the finished basement.

The door from the garage leads straight into the family room.

The dimmer, light switches, jacks, and receptacles were to the left of the door as you would face it from the family room. It would be behind the table with lamp you can see in a picture. I am pretty sure the orb entered the electric receptacle. A telephone was on a table near the switches.

Some of the inside pictures were taken from the steps leading up to the foyer.

The house in Trent had hot water baseboard heat as well.

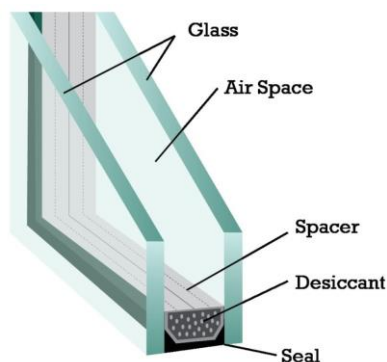
2024-02-12 WH: Thermopane windows

> Would not Thermopane be a better insulator than a single pane?

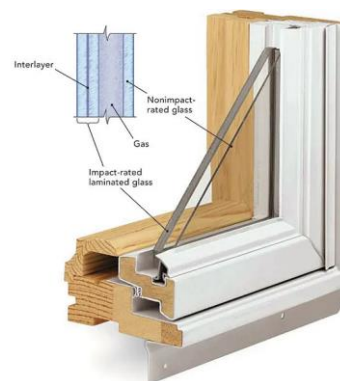
Yes, definitely also in the electrical sense. It would let electromagnetic pulses through, i.e. the EMP of a lightning strike, but nothing in a material form, unless it had a hole in it.

Would it still be possible to find out what type of Thermopane glass was used in your house in Trent? In particular, it might make a difference if there was an "anti-shatter film" attached to the glass or not. That is a relatively thick (8-12 mil) but invisible Mylar foil. This would also be added for security reasons, to keep burglars out even if they smash the glass. In Germany, this can be a prerequisite if you want to get insurance for a house. It may be the same in the USA.

The glass most likely did not have an IR reflecting "Low-E" coating, which only became common in the 1990ies (in Germany).



Standard Thermopane



Impact resistant glass

Reply

The sliding doors in Trent would have had a high quality circa 1984. We went first class on everything there. I can't say anything more about what coatings they had. Most of the windows were Pella. Maybe the sliding doors were too. The frames on these were wood.

2024-02-12 WH: BL delay after lightning strike

This is a fairly important point, that the BL did NOT appear in coincidence with the lightning, but only became visible a short time after it.

- You mentioned that the delay from the lightning strike until you saw the BL was “a second or so”. Is it possible to narrow this time down a bit more? Could it also have been 2.5 or 3 seconds instead?
- Was this delay about the same on both occasions?

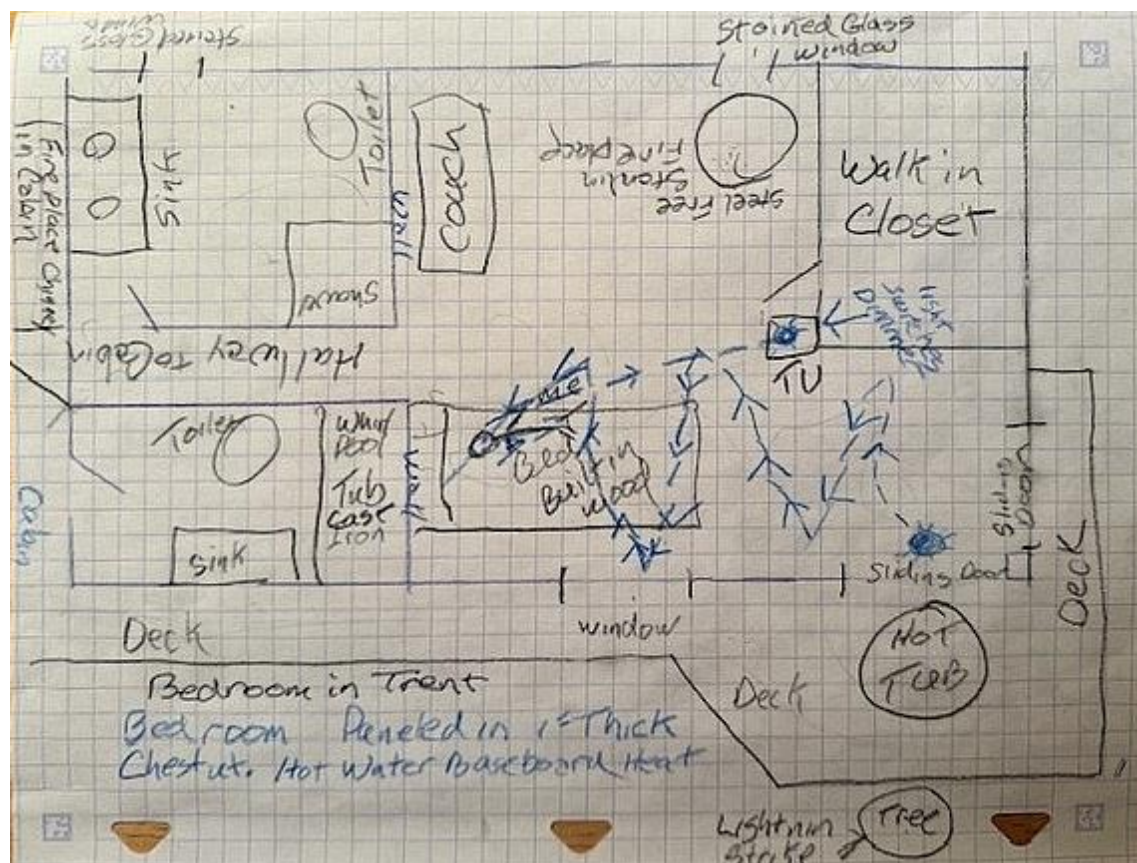
Something must have happened between the time when the lightning hit the trees until the BL appeared in front of the glass inside your room. It seems that either the BL takes a certain time to materialize, or that it was already there, but only became luminous and visible after that time.

Reply

That is very possible. 2 or 3 seconds. I don't remember it being instantaneous. There was a delay. Yes, the delay occurred on both occasions.

I can't be sure but they were both the same length of time in appearing.

Trent



2024-02-13 JC

It occurs to me that both exit points were in the vicinity of TVs turned on. Ceiling lights turned on with a dimmer switch, light switches at shoulder height, electric receptacles and cable TV jacks close to the baseboards. Then we had the baseboard heat with copper pipes surrounding both rooms. Seems more than coincidence.

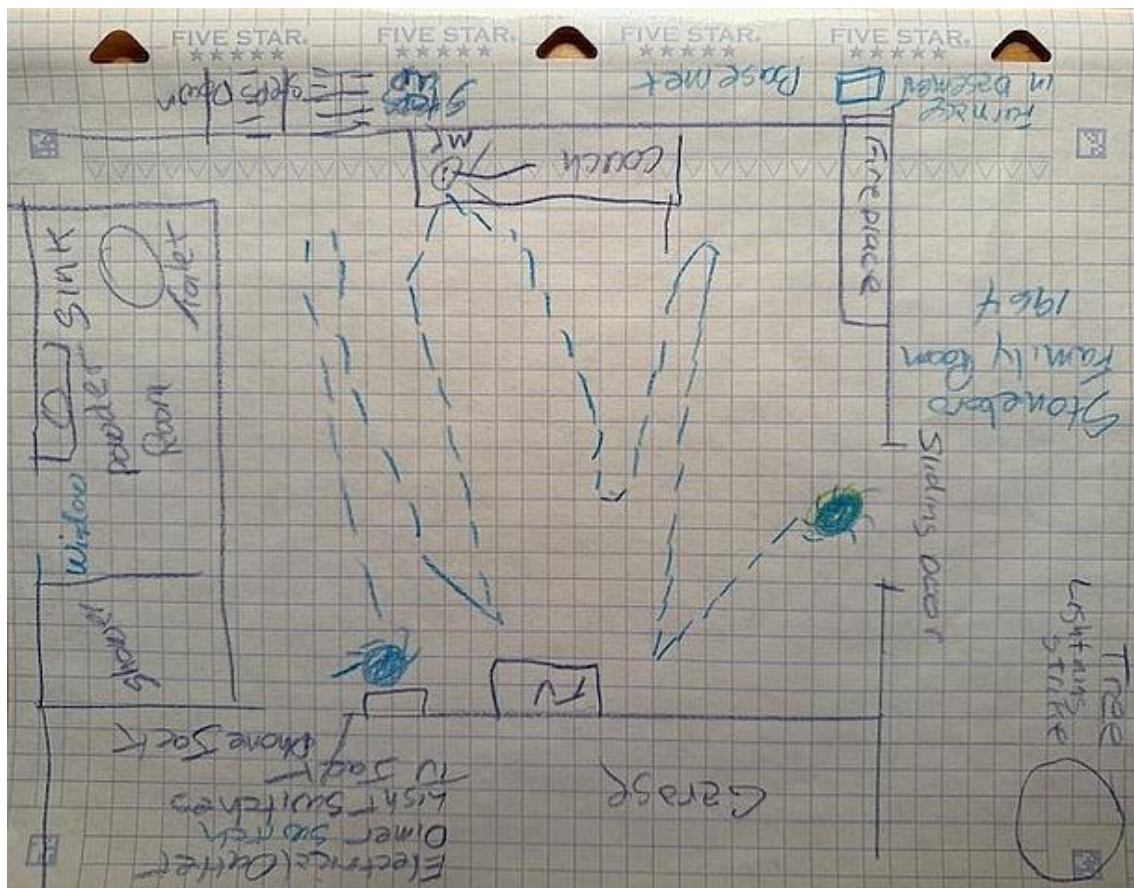
WH: These were normal TV sets with a cathode ray tube? I think there were no others at that time. How big were these TV sets?

JC: The TV in Stoneboro was a floor model. In Trent it was a medium size TV. It stood on a 4' Masonite stand with a glass door on front. The TV was the type used in motels. I bought it from a motel surplus. I don't remember the screen sizes. The TV in Stoneboro was sitting on the right wall as you face the fireplace. Were you able to make anything of my drawing? I remembered that the dimmer and switches were just to the left and behind the TV in Trent.

WH: What kind of stove was the "Starline" steel free fireplace?

JC: It was a free standing fireplace. Made from steel. It was like an upside down funnel with a metal chimney pipe. A part was cut out on the front to load the logs. It had a mesh screen in the hole. The bottom had about 4" of insulating material like cement with asbestos in it. Don't know what it was.

Stoneboro



2024-02-14 WH: Fireplace and TV sets

Thanks for the Stoneboro drawing.

The BLs really criss-crossed through the room in both instances.

The "Starline" fireplace must also have had a stove pipe which went through the ceiling and above the roof?

About the TV sets: were they both color TVs or was the one in Stoneboro still black and white? Perhaps the BLs have a higher affinity for color TVs over the black and white ones, because they run at a much higher voltage (around 45 kV in a color TV vs. 18 kV for B/W).

You could feel the static when passing a finger over the picture tube.

I know of several reports where a BL jumped at the picture tube of a TV set, usually ruining it. This shouldn't happen anymore with LCD TVs.

Now I'm really curious about your rendering of the ball lightning itself.

JC: Yes, the free standing fire place had a chimney pipe through and above the roof. There was a stone hearth under the fireplace about 6" higher than the wooden floor.

The TV in Trent was color. I'm not entirely sure but the TV in Stoneboro was probably black and white.

Yes, the BLs zig-zagged across the room. They would tend to stop and then change direction. Sometimes they stopped and continued in the same direction. Both times they stopped directly over me. I dared not move. I got the impression they changed speed slightly. I am quite sure both moved quickly when they got near the receptacle and TV. They seemed like they were sucked in. I also had the feeling something was attracting them as they changed direction. I will send the rendering tomorrow.

WH:

How fast did the BL move, walking speed? And how long was it visible all together?

At what height did it move around the room?

The center of the door where it appeared would be at about 4 ft.

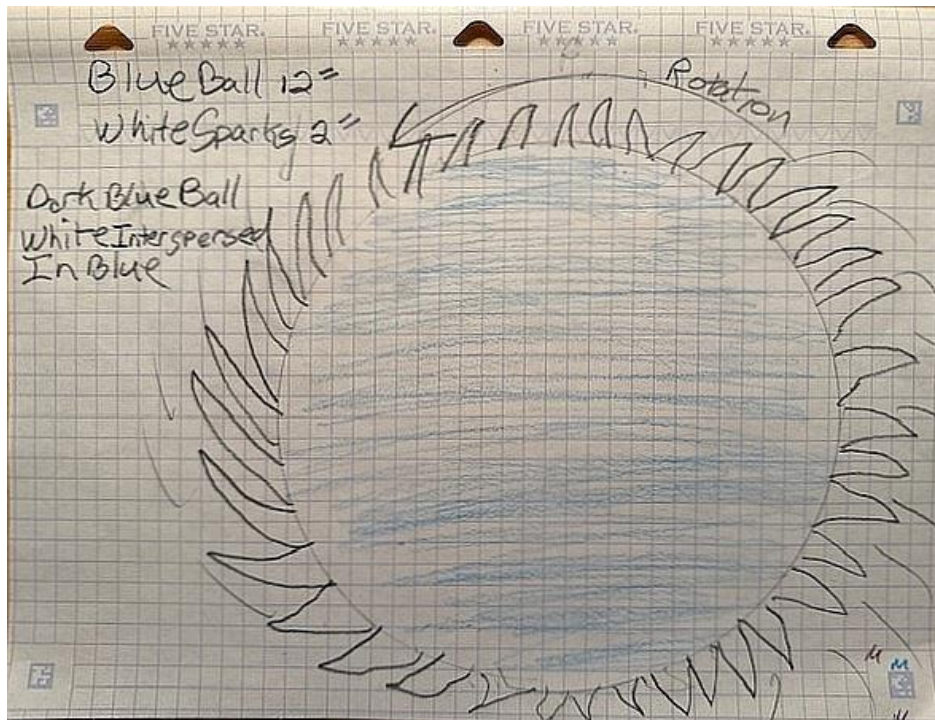
JC:

I would say walking speed would be too fast. They both hovered frequently, maybe 4 or 5 times. Then they would start slowly moving. At times, they seemed to start off from the hover a little faster. Again, after they hovered, it seems they were attracted to something.

My guess on the height would be about 5'. I believe they rose some, just after their pause inside the door.

Remember there were recessed ceiling lights with small floodlights. Maybe 8 in Trent. Maybe 4 to 8 in Stoneboro. All were run through the dimmer switches.

In my best estimate, 10 to 15 seconds from start to finish.



WH: I would say that drawing such a sketch 60 and 40 years after it happened is quite good!

Did you see any of these "sparks" fly away, or did these stay attached, like tentacles?
Is the number of sparks or tentacles around the circumference about as many as you saw?
I counted 39 around the sphere.

The sparks in the horizontal middle of the BL appear longer than those on the top and bottom.
Maybe only because that was the near the end of the paper, or did the BL also show such differences?

Were the sparks brighter than the blue sphere?

JC: I believe they flew away. I can't say at all how many there were.
That is because of the paper. I think they were the same size all the way around.
Yes, the sparks were brighter than the blue.

Cherry Tree



Ravine on the left side of the house in Stoneboro

WH: There is one big tree on the left side, partially visible. Is that the one you referred to, close to where the cherry tree was?

This must have been the species: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Prunus_serotina

JC: You will see a ravine running alongside the house. The tree is no longer there. I checked when I took the pictures. If you look at the picture shot down the side of the house, you will see a tree growing on the edge of the ravine near where the picture was taken. The cherry tree was near the tree you see in the picture. You really just see the trunk of the tree as it is on the edge of the picture.

JC: Yes, the partially visible tree on the left. The cherry was 3' closer to the house and on the edge of the level yard. Not down the bank.

The cherry tree was much larger than the tree you showed me. At least 2' in diameter and taller than the house.

If you look closely, expanding the picture you sent back to me, you will see a log on the ground beside the tree at the edge of the picture. That is most likely the cherry tree. It looks like it was sawed down some years ago.

Stoneboro History:

Stoneboro area was a Revolutionary War land grant to 5 soldiers. The land grants were a form of payment from the new Government. One soldier sold his portion to a free black man for \$5. He founded Liberia. Probably around 1790. Blacks and Indians lived there together. Runaway slaves from the South could not be recovered by their owners in Northern PA. They came by the Underground Railroad. In 1850 the Fugitive Slave Act was enacted. Now slave owners could recover slaves in PA. The runaway slaves had to move on to Canada.

Stoneboro was a terminus on the Underground Railroad. The town was first named Liberia before it was Stoneboro. The town was first settled by runaway slaves. There were 2 black family's left in Stoneboro when we built the house. The first two houses you see on the left of Elm St Extension are the houses where the black families lived.

I was working at clearing behind the house to put in grass. Old Joe Polk, a 90 year old black man, came walking up with his cane. He said, "That old glass and stones you're cleaning is where the log cabin I was born in was. My mother had been a slave. That hill you see we called rattle snake hill. We had to burn it 5 times to get rid of the rattle snakes." That hillside you showed me the suspected cherry tree is rattle snake hill.

Personal Info 2024-02-17

WH: What was your impression, of what the ball lightning could have been made?

JC: My first impression in Stoneboro was that it was a fragment of the lightning itself. I thought it might have bounced from the tree to the ground and then bounced to the glass door. I thought it must have come through the glass, slowing it down and making it spin. By going to the outlet I thought for sure it was an electrical entity.

Granted I was 14 years old but I was a serious student and was deeply into any science I studied. I studied chemistry, physics, biology, math to calculus all as far as I could go in high school.

At Grove City College I had the privilege of studying Economics with Dr. Hans F. Sennholz. He was a Luftwaffe pilot who was shot down and was a prisoner of war held in Arizona. He had a PhD already. After his release he studied at NYU with Ludwig von Mises, the father of Austrian Economics. Mises developed the first explanation of value. That is the Theory of Marginal Utility. Von Mises came to Grove City College to lecture several times while I was there.

I ended up working in institutional investments with Federated Investors. We invented the Money Market Funds. We sold them to the banks by the billions. It was quite a time. We were flying around the US in Lear Jets. Much of my time was spent entertaining bankers. Million dollar parties from Hawaii to Aspen to the Waldorf in NY. I retired from that at age 39.

In spite of the money and fun I have often regretted not having gone on somehow with science. Thank you for your explanation.

What I have told you about these BLs is true and as accurate as I can remember.

Addendum



Stoneboro – family room in 1966

This is a picture as it was of the family room in Stoneboro. You can see the lights in the ceiling. The black and white TV on the right wall. The couch where I was lying is on the opposite wall. Metal screen on the fire place. The sliding door is behind the curtain. My brother on his birthday with a 007 spy case.

WH: Are you twins? Below you wrote that it was your brothers birthday. I suppose there are several birthday photos in this album. Anyway, 1966 is close enough.

JC: No I am 5 years older than my brother. I did not realize it was my birthday until you asked for the date the picture was taken. Jan 7 1966 was the date on the back of the picture. I assumed it was my brother's birthday since he is on the picture.

2024-11-20 **WH: Spiky ball lightning**



I hope to find you well and I'm still pondering about your report about the two ball lightning observations. Would you think that this spiky little ball has any resemblance to the ball lightning which you saw? If you just see the circumference of it while it was spinning, it would indeed look like a circular saw blade.

Could you perhaps make another drawing of the ball lightning, maybe with colored pencils? If possible, I would like to use that in some form of publication.

JC: Nice to hear from you again. Yes, I would say what I saw was an orb looked at from one face. I would agree it would look flat like a saw blade. When I squint at your ball, I don't see the protrusions, except on the outer rim. That looks what I saw. However, white was interspersed. The tendrils on the outer edge seemed to curve a bit from the rotation. There seemed to be sparks coming off the tendrils. I will attempt to draw it again.

JC: Is the last way I drew it acceptable? I am not a very talented artist.

WH: Sure enough, I can use what you already drew or make a similar artwork myself. I found your drawings quite refreshing :)